In 2023, we saw the promise of AI and what it can potentially achieve for everyone on the planet. There is no question that we are in the midst of a massive platform shift, for the new generation of AI is going to transform pretty much every sector, every category of computing. It is not just a technological advancement; it is a societal shift propelling us into a future where innovation takes centre-stage. In just the past few months, we have seen the ever-expanding ways in which AI has improved lives. By acting as a co-pilot in people's lives, foundation models like GPT-4 are turning search into a more powerful tool for research and improving productivity for people at work. And for any parent who has struggled to help their 13-year-old child through an algebra homework assignment, AI-based assistance is a helpful tutor. That said, AI's real potential is in its promise to unlock some of the world's most elusive problems.

For nations and societies, AI offers an opportunity to democratise access to technology and create impact at scale, solving some of our pressing challenges in areas like education, healthcare, food security and sustainability.

For organisations, AI helps business leaders reimagine, simplify and optimise their business processes, whether it's sales, marketing, finance or customer service. The speed and efficiency AI brings to previously time-consuming and cumbersome processes will have a ripple effect, reducing wastage, defects, response time and reshaping productivity.

For individuals, generative AI represents the freedom to take on new challenges requiring human ingenuity and creativity while co-pilots help with tasks that would have otherwise weighed down their workday. This will radically transform how computers help us think, plan and act. Just as we can't imagine computing today without a keyboard, mouse or multi-touch, going forward, we won't be able to imagine computing without co-pilots and natural language prompts that intuitively help us with summarisation, reviewing, modifying and acting.

TAKEAWAYS

- **India has one of the largest AI talent concentrations; harnessing it is key**
- **AI will free us to take on projects needing human ingenuity as 'co-pilots' handle workday tasks**
- **India is well-positioned to lead the global dialogue on AI safeguards with positive regulation**

India's Opportunity

India is at the forefront of driving innovation in digital public goods, creating a template for the world to follow with initiatives like Aadhaar and UPI. With AI, the opportunity to drive billion-scale impact goes up manifold.

Looking at the AI opportunity for India, I get excited about three key things. First, the potential to revolutionise every industry and create new business models that generate global investments and job opportunities. Second, how AI is transforming productivity by freeing up people's time to focus on innovation and strategic thinking. Third, the opportunity to democratise access to technology and empower communities across India.

Today, from banking to healthcare to manufacturing to education and government services, AI is changing the pace of innovation in every possible industry. We are working closely with organisations across India on AI applications to empower citizens. For instance, Microsoft collaborated with MakeMyTrip to introduce voice-assisted travel booking in Indian languages. This is a powerful example of AI's relevance, enabling access to travel services for people in the language of their choice. An IDC (International Data Corporation) study found out that for every dollar a company invests in AI, business leaders in India realise an average return of 3.8x dollars. This is demonstrable business value.

With AI as enabler, India has a huge opportunity to be a global innovation and talent hub. It already has one of the largest developer communities and AI talent concentrations, according to Stanford University's AI Index Report. Harnessing this talent and skilling the country's youth and workforce will be the biggest lever of India's AI success.

Responsible Innovation

No single technology in recent history has held the promise for such universal, far-reaching and impactful transformation at so many levels as AI. Yet, amidst this excitement, a critical mandate remains—as we delve into this AI-powered future, it is imperative that we innovate responsibly. All of us who build, deploy or use AI have a collective obligation to do so responsibly.

It is critical that AI products and governance processes be informed by diverse multi-stakeholder perspectives. Establishing safeguards for AI demands a collective sense of responsibility that extends beyond technology companies to industry, academia, civil society and governments. India is well-positioned to lead the dialogue on AI with positive regulation and show the way for responsible AI development and deployment. This is India's moment to reimagine its future with AI and advance its goal posts for inclusive economic growth and progress. ■